

EDUCATIONPLUS

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Padmakumar Nair

Few topics in higher education receive as much attention as industry-academia collaboration. Every policy document, accreditation framework, and university strategy seems to ask the same question: What must universities do differently to become more relevant to industry?

While it is an important question, I increasingly wonder whether we have been asking the wrong one. Over the years, we have created an idealised picture of university-industry collaboration. Every student should complete a meaningful internship. Every professor should work on industry-sponsored research. Universities and companies should jointly develop products, technologies, and services. Graduates should seamlessly transition into employment. It is an inspiring vision, but is it practical?

According to the All-India Survey on Higher Education (AISHE), India produces around one crore graduates every year. But the country generates only about 10 to 15 lakh entry-level graduate jobs annually. The economy, undoubtedly, creates many more jobs, but relatively few are high-skilled positions requiring a university degree.

This mismatch fundamentally changes the discussion. Even if every company genuinely wanted to collaborate with universities, can industry realisti-



cally provide quality internships for millions of students every year? Can companies dedicate engineers, managers, scientists, and designers to mentor such numbers? Can every faculty member undertake industry-funded research? Can every university sustain advanced laboratories capable of supporting collaborative product development?

Capacity matters
Meaningful collaboration depends on several impor-

tant preconditions. Students must possess sufficient technical competence before entering the industry. Companies must have the organisational bandwidth to supervise interns and collaborative projects. Faculty members must be engaged in high-quality research that industry finds valuable. Universities must possess research infrastructure, labs, and administrative systems capable of supporting sustained partnerships.

Internationally, countries such as Germany, Japan, South Korea, and several European nations have built stronger university-industry ecosystems that evolved through decades of sustained industrial development, strong research universities, and carefully designed public policies.

Even the U.S., often regarded as the benchmark for innovation, does not achieve the universal model of industry-academia collaboration that many

discussions implicitly assume. Outstanding partnerships are concentrated in particular universities, industries, and research-intensive institutions rather than being the norm across the entire higher education system.

Questions to ask
Perhaps, then, the issue is not that universities are underperforming but that our expectations are unrealistic. This suggests that it is time to ask: What exactly are we trying to achieve? Is the primary objective employability, innovation, technology transfer, entrepreneurship, regional economic development, or workforce readiness? Different goals require different models of collaboration. A single framework cannot serve every discipline or institution.

The second question is how we incentivise companies to collaborate with universities. Industry cannot be expected to collaborate simply because policymakers encourage it. Companies invest time and resources when they perceive clear value, whether through access to talent, cutting-edge research, intellectual property, or long-term competitiveness.

Finally, the most practical question of all: if deep industry collaboration cannot realistically reach every student, how should universities prepare graduates for successful careers? Perhaps the answer lies less in attempting to re-

plicate industry inside the university and more in developing graduates who can learn quickly after entering the workforce.

The future belongs to graduates who possess strong analytical ability, excellent communication skills, teamwork, intellectual humility, ethical judgement, and the capacity for lifelong learning. Technical knowledge will matter, but the ability to continuously acquire new knowledge may matter even more. Industry-academia collaboration should certainly be expanded wherever it creates genuine value. It remains indispensable for research-intensive universities, innovation ecosystems, and technology-driven sectors. However, it should not become the sole measure of educational quality or institutional success.

The future of higher education will depend not merely on increasing the quantity of collaboration between universities and industry, but on designing models that are realistic, scalable, and aligned with the needs of both. Perhaps the time has come to stop asking how universities can become more like industry and, instead, ask a more fundamental question: What kind of graduates does society need, and what is the most practical way to prepare them?

Views are personal

The writer is Vice Chancellor, Thapar Institute of Engineering and Technology.

SCHOLARSHIPS

DXC Progressing Minds Scholarship
An initiative by DXC Technology.
Eligibility: Open to women and transgender students pursuing graduation in a STEM-related field across India who have scored minimum 60% in the previous semester/year and have an annual family income not exceeding ₹400,000.
Rewards: ₹50,000 (fixed and one time)
Application: Online
Deadline: October 10
www.b4s.in/edge/DXCS8

Winnie Sun Scholarship
Offered by the Lotus Petal Foundation.
Eligibility: Indian girls who have secured admission to MBBS in the 2026-27 financial year and scored minimum 70% in Class 10 and 12 (60% for SC/ST/OBC students) and have an annual family income of less than ₹500,000.

Rewards: Up to ₹65,000 for the course duration.
Application: Online
Deadline: October 30
www.b4s.in/edge/WISS2

Nirankari Rajmata Scholarship
Offered by Sant Nirankari Charitable Foundation
Eligibility: Students who secured admission in recognised institutions through a competitive written test in eligible courses such as Engineering, Medicine, MBA, PGDM, Architecture, CA, CFA, LLB, or Journalism and Mass Communication and scored 90% or above in Class 12 and have an annual family income below ₹500,000.
Rewards: Up to ₹75,000 per annum.
Application: Education Department, Sant Nirankari Charitable Foundation, 80A, Avtar Marg, Sant Nirankari Colony, Delhi 110009
Deadline: November 30
www.b4s.in/edge/NRS8

Courtesy: Buddy4study.com

Anandi Fellowship

Bombay Shaving Company invites applications for the Anandi Fellowship, which aims to identify entrepreneurial talent among young Indians through the Anand-NEAT (Nationwide Entrepreneurship Acumen Test) 2026

scheduled to be held in the first week of December 2026.
Eligibility: Open to school students in Class 11 and 12, or in the first year of undergraduate programmes. No start-up, prototype, or prior experience is required to register.
Deadline: October 15
For more details, visit tinyurl.com/56w36f6c



OFF THE EDGE
Nandini Raman

I am in Class 12 (Humanities) and plan to pursue B.A. (Hons) Political Science at Delhi University. I am interested in geopolitics, national security, and strategic studies. Are there entry-level roles after graduation, or will I need a Master's? Name withheld

While you can be hired as a programme/research assistant, research intern, or corporate risk analyst after a Bachelor's degree, a Master's in International Relations, Strategic Studies, or Public Policy is generally required to become a policy analyst or strategic advisor. A Ph.D. is highly valued in security think tanks, but less critical if you pivot to corporate strategic risk.

New Delhi is the epicentre of think tanks and corporate firms. Strategic and defence think-tanks include MP-IDSA, ORF, Carnegie India, CSEP, and CSDR. They offer internships, although postgraduate qualifications are often preferred. CAPS, CLAWS, and NMF occasionally take civilian interns to assist military fellows.

Geopolitical risk consultancies such as Control Risks, Eurasia Group, Sibylline, and S-RM hire analysts to monitor threat landscapes, political stability, and security risks for international businesses. The big Management consultancies have government and public sector advisory wings. Large global tech firms hire trust and safety or global intelligence analysts to track geopolitical events affecting operations.

I am a first-year BHMS student but am wondering if this is the right choice.

Prepare with confidence
Uncertain about your career options? Low on self-confidence? This column may help

Should I attempt NEET again? I like treating patients but have no confidence that I will succeed in being a physician. Azja

Dear Azja,
What is your belief regarding homoeopathy vs allopathy? If you believe that you can only be a medical doctor by doing MBBS and that homoeopathy does not feel right for you, consider taking NEET again. But if your lack of confidence stems from a general fear of diagnosing patients, making high-stakes clinical diagnoses, or interacting with the sick, MBBS comes with even higher clinical pressure, heavier emergency duties, and intense competition for post-graduation (NEET PG). Talk to your current batchmates who are probably going through something similar.

Consider completing your BHMS and then pivot to clinical research. Also explore Hospital Operations and Administration through an MBA in Healthcare Management. You can also consider a Master's in Public Health, Pharmacovigilance, Health Insurance, or Medical Analytics.

I have finished BCA and plan to pursue a career in cricket. But I am also highly motivated to prepare for the UPSC. I want to have a strong backup but am confused about whether to pursue a Master's or an LLB. Which degree will give me time and flexibility to focus on cricket and UPSC? Is there any other option? Tejas

Dear Tejas,
Cricket and UPSC require extreme focus and huge blocks of uninterrupted time. Cricket demands hours of physical training, field presence, and extensive travel for matches, while UPSC requires massive discipline, consistency, and analytical reading.

Choosing a Master's in a subject that doubles as your UPSC Optional Subject, such as Public Administration, Political Science, History, or Geography, can help. If you choose distance education through universities such as IGNOU, attendance pressure is almost negligible. A low-residency Master's could also give you time for cricket nets and tournaments.

LL.B. will not offer the same flexibility. The Bar Council of India mandates minimum attendance requirements for regular LL.B. courses. A legal degree also requires regular moot courts, internships, and intensive semester exams. But this is a professional qualification that allows you to work independently in litigation or enter corporate law.

If your options do not work, you will be in your mid-to-late 20s when you enter the job market. An MCA builds directly upon your BCA foundation and can lead to software engineering, systems architecture and data management roles. Your decision rests on what you want to prioritise right now.

I graduated in Mechanical Engineering in 2022 and have been preparing for competitive exams, but I haven't cracked any. I have

no idea what to do next and don't want to depend on my family. How can I get a job? Adithya

Dear Adithya,
You are conditioned to think that your worth is tied to clearing a massive exam. It isn't. The industry doesn't care about your exam scores; it cares if you can solve a problem today. Dust yourself off, change your direction, and start moving.

You already have a four-year gap. What are you waiting for now? Break the cycle, stop depending on your family, and build a meaningful career. A 'meaningful' job should simply pay you an independent salary. Do not look for ultimate purpose in your first job after a gap. You will find meaning from earning your own money and contributing at home. Once financially secure, you can map out a larger corporate trajectory.

Corporate recruiters may hesitate about gaps because they fear your skills have rusted. Reframe your last four years' experience. Consider short-term certifications in HVAC/MEP Design or Piping Design and Engineering, with opportunities in manufacturing, infrastructure, data centres, oil, gas and power.

Disclaimer: This column is merely a guiding voice and provides advice and suggestions on education and careers.

The writer is a practising counsellor and a trainer. Send your questions to eduplus.thehindu@gmail.com with the subject line Off the Edge

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Rakesh Dosi

Thousands of crores of scholarship funds in India remain unutilised every year, not because the money is unavailable but because many deserving students never discover the opportunities created for them.

A first-generation learner may qualify for multiple scholarships without ever hearing about them. At the same time, corporates with genuine CSR intent often struggle to identify deserving beneficiaries or measure the impact of their investments.

This is not a funding crisis. It is a discovery crisis. Solving it requires rethinking scholarships not as isolated schemes but as a connected ecosystem where opportunity finds the student, not the other way around.

Better connections
Today, India has over 4.33 crore students enrolled in higher education and the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 envisions a Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER) of 50% by 2035. Government scholarship programmes continue to expand, CSR spending has crossed ₹34,900 crore, and education remains the largest area of corporate social investment. Yet scholarship opportunities remain invisible for many students in aspirational districts, tribal communities, and smaller towns. The question is not "how do we fund more?" It is "how do we connect better?"

That challenge is largely structural. India's scholarship landscape has evolved across ministries, states, institutions and CSR programmes, creating a rich but fragmented ecosystem. The National Scholarship Portal has simplified access, but students still navigate different eligibility norms, documentation requirements, and timelines. Success often depends less on merit than on geogra-



From funding to finding
How technology-enabled public-private partnerships can unlock India's scholarship promise

phy, institutional support, or awareness. Corporates face a similar problem: without transparent beneficiary discovery and outcome measurement, even well-intentioned CSR programmes struggle to scale.

What matters most is the last mile. Technology succeeds only when it reaches the citizen who needs it most, regardless of geography or digital literacy. India already has Aadhaar, UPI and DigiLocker. The next opportunity lies in combining this with Artificial Intelligence. Through the ₹10,300 crore IndiaAI Mission, India is creating the compute capacity and indigenous language models needed to make public services far more intelligent and personalised.

AI help
Applied to scholarships, the possibilities are significant. AI can automatically match verified student profiles with eligible Central, State, and CSR scholar-

ships, deliver personalised recommendations in regional languages, enable one-time Aadhaar-based applications with digital verification, facilitate seamless Direct Benefit Transfers, and generate real-time outcome dashboards for governments and corporate funders alike.

Several states have already demonstrated elements of this future. Rajasthan, Odisha, and Andhra Pradesh have shown how technology can simplify scholarship administration and improve targeting. What is missing is a common interoperability layer, shared standards, APIs, and data exchange which allows successful models to scale nationally while preserving state-level innovation.

CSR in India has evolved from philanthropy to a strategic driver of social impact, with education accounting for nearly 44% of CSR expenditure. Yet many

scholarship programmes continue to operate in isolation. The opportunity now is not simply to invest more, but to invest differently. To realise that potential, CSR itself must evolve in four important ways:

- Build on shared infrastructure and integrate with interoperable scholarship platforms instead of creating siloed initiatives.
- Prioritise transparency to enable end-to-end digital verification, fund tracking, audit trails, and outcome reporting.
- Co-create with government and align CSR scholarships with central and state schemes to improve reach and reduce duplication.
- Measure long-term outcomes by tracking student retention, graduation, employability, and social impact.

Working together
This is where Public-Private Partnerships become indispensable. Government contributes scale, legitimacy, and trusted public infrastructure. Technology partners bring innovation, AI capabilities, and operational excellence. Civil society provides the community relationships and last-mile trust that digital systems alone cannot create. Together, they can build a scholarship ecosystem that is transparent, interoperable and truly student-centric.

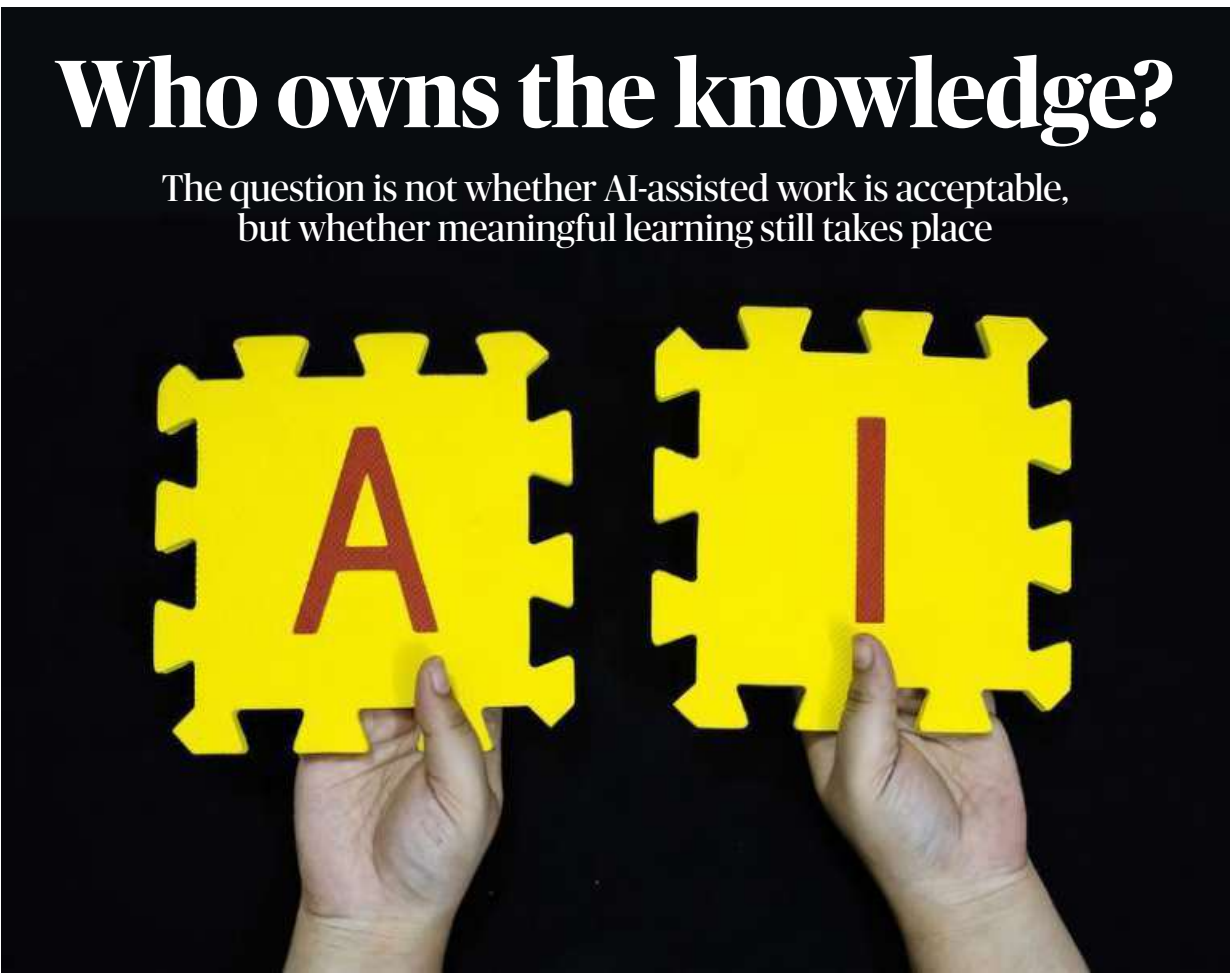
The architecture already exists. The defining question for the next decade is not how much we spend on scholarships. It is whether every rupee reaches the student it was intended to support. That is the ecosystem we must build. The time to build it is now.

The writer is the Chief Business and Product Officer, Protean eGov Technologies.

Andrews Samraj

Artificial Intelligence has become an increasingly common presence in higher education, influencing the way students study, research, and complete academic tasks. Whether it is helping to generate ideas, analyse information, write content, or solve technical problems, AI-powered tools are making learning processes faster and more accessible. However, as students rely more on these tools, an important question emerges: when AI contributes to the creation of academic work, how much of the learning can truly be attributed to the student?

For generations, education has been built around the idea that meaningful learning comes from actively engaging with concepts, evaluating information, and developing one's own perspectives. Academic activities such as assignments, projects, and examinations are intended to strengthen analytical thinking, creativity, and the ability to solve problems independently.



Challenges emerge when students depend heavily on AI to complete these tasks. While AI-generated work may be accurate and

well-structured, relying on it without actively participating in the learning process can reduce opportunities for deeper

understanding and personal intellectual growth.

Engagement in learning
While AI has sparked im-

portant discussions about the nature of learning, it also presents significant opportunities to enhance education. When used res-

possibly, AI can serve as a valuable resource that helps students engage more effectively with knowledge and develop a deeper understanding of their subjects. The key issue, therefore, is not whether AI is involved, but how it is involved.

A student who uses AI to brainstorm ideas, understand a topic, or improve the structure of an essay is still actively engaged in the learning process. He/she remains responsible for evaluating the information, making decisions, and developing original insights. Students who depend solely on AI outputs without reflecting on or interpreting the information may achieve short-term academic outcomes while missing deeper learning opportunities. The difference lies in participation. Learning occurs when students think, question, analyse, and reflect, not simply when they submit completed work.

The increasing use of AI in academic work is reshaping long-standing ideas about originality and authorship. Educational institutions may need to rethink how they evaluate authen-

tic student contributions. Instead of assessing only the final submission, greater attention may be given to the learner's approach: how they explored ideas, assessed information, applied knowledge, and arrived at their conclusions.

Ownership
Another important consideration is intellectual ownership. If an AI tool contributes suggestions, structures, or even entire paragraphs, who owns the resulting work? While current academic standards generally recognise the student as the owner and responsible author, ethical concerns remain. Transparency becomes essential. Students should acknowledge when AI has been used significantly in the creation of academic work, just as they would cite external sources or references. Such openness promotes academic integrity while encouraging responsible use of technology.

The increasing adoption of AI in education underscores the need to cultivate skills such as critical thinking, ethical decision-making, creativity, emotional intelligence, teamwork,

and the ability to understand context, which distinguish human capability from machine output. As AI becomes more proficient at generating information, the ability to think independently and make well-informed decisions will remain a significant advantage.

Ultimately, the question is not whether AI-assisted work is acceptable, but whether meaningful learning still takes place. AI can provide information, suggestions, and support, but it cannot replace the personal intellectual journey that defines education. Knowledge becomes truly valuable only when learners engage with it, challenge it, and connect it to their own understanding and experiences. Ultimately, while AI can provide support and guidance, meaningful learning continues to depend on active engagement, thoughtful reflection, and the uniquely human ability to make sense of knowledge.

The writer is Professor, Department of Computer Science and Engineering, School of Engineering and Technology at CMR University, Bengaluru.

Beyond grammar

Why teaching English should move from being a subject to acquiring a language



WIDE ANGLE
Albert P' Rayan

Recently, I came across the following three questions in an exam paper on Communication Skills taught at the tertiary level: (1) What is the difference between an adjective and an adverb? (2) Define a gerund. (3) What is the difference between a transitive verb and an intransitive verb?

It is rather surprising that, even today, English grammar continues to be taught in colleges, and students are tested on their knowledge of grammatical terms, despite having spent around 14 years learning English at school. Did the person who set the question paper ever ask themselves whether answering such questions can actually help students become more proficient in English?

Knowing what an adjective, an adverb, a gerund, or a transitive verb is does not mean that a student can communicate effectively in English. If our goal is to develop students' communicative competence, simply teaching grammatical rules and bombarding learners with grammatical terminology may not be the most effective approach.

Grammar does have a role to play in language learning, but it should serve communication rather than become an end in itself. Students need opportunities to use English meaningfully; to speak, listen, read, and write in contexts that resemble real-life communication.

The need of the hour is to move beyond teaching

grammar as knowledge about the language and focus on helping students use the language effectively. International English proficiency exams like the International English Language Testing System (IELTS) and the Test of English as a Foreign Language (TOEFL), which operate on the philosophy of communicative competence, do not feature an isolated grammar section. In 2005, when TOEFL iBT was introduced, the section "Structure and Written Expression" was removed to prioritise real-world communication.

Teachers of English often bombard students with grammar rules and terminology, probably because the curriculum and teaching methods are outdated and because it is easier to assess students through MCQs and fill-in-the-blank exercises. This, however, kills students' curiosity to explore the language and makes them see English as a boring subject to learn.

One of the reasons many students are not proficient in English is that they have neither been taught nor learnt the language effectively. Most do not have the habit of reading books beyond their textbooks. Although various studies have shown that reading is one of the most effective ways of helping learners acquire a target language, many teachers of English fail to promote or instil the habit of reading among their students. Perhaps they are also not sufficiently aware of the distinction between 'learning a language' and 'acquiring a language'.

Language acquisition experts such as Stephen Krashen have highlighted that pleasure reading, or reading for enjoyment, is an effective way of acquiring a target language.

When learners read a text that they find interesting, they become so engaged in its content that they forget they are reading in a foreign language. Engaging texts expose learners to vocabulary, grammar, and sentence patterns in meaningful contexts. Unlike isolated grammar instruction, pleasure reading helps learners develop communicative competence through meaningful interaction with texts.

In one of my interviews with Krashen in 2016, he suggested that students should begin with texts that are easy to understand and interesting to them and then progress to self-selected pleasure reading. He further advised students to seek out "texts that are genuinely compelling" and to "watch TV and movies but only if they are really interested in the film or the programme." In other words, language learning, particularly at higher levels, should be driven not merely by the desire to learn the language but by the desire to use it for meaningful purposes.

In the Indian context, English as a second language (ESL) should be treated not as a subject to be studied but as a language to be acquired. Reading books about swimming may provide knowledge about the sport, but only practice can make someone a swimmer. Similarly, grammar books and memorising grammatical terms alone cannot develop communicative competence. If we shift the focus from scoring marks to using and acquiring the language, can we bring about a meaningful change in the way English is taught and learnt?

The writer is an ELT resource person and education columnist. Email rayanaln@yahoo.co.uk

Varun Satia

Marketing has always been about growth. What has changed in the digital era is the nature of growth itself. In a world where customer journeys unfold across apps, platforms and multiple touchpoints, businesses must understand how to acquire users, activate them quickly, keep them engaged, deepen their relationship with the brand, and earn loyalty over time. Growth Marketing has emerged in response to this shift.

Traditional marketing was largely designed around awareness and acquisition. It excelled at generating visibility, building recall, and driving initial consideration, often through channels where measurement was broad and feedback loops were slow. Growth Marketing extends that mandate. It brings the same strategic objective of building demand, but applies it across the full customer lifecycle. It is therefore more measurable, analytical, and accountable to business outcomes. In a world where success depends not only on winning a customer but keeping them engaged over time, Growth Marketing



has become a critical business function.

This explains why the role is gaining ground so quickly in India. Recent hiring trends show that entry-level digital marketing demand has remained resilient, while specialist roles are becoming more prominent. At the same time, professional networks already show thousands of openings with "growth" in the role title, signalling that this is now a mainstream career pathway within the marketing ecosystem.

What it involves

The rise of this role is changing what career readiness should look like for students. The question is no longer whether a candidate has a particular degree but whether they can build hands-on experience, understand customer behaviour, and contribute meaningfully from day one. That means learning through live projects and being guided by expert practitioners wherever possible. Industry-recognised certifications

Jeel Gandhi

Open any college student's LinkedIn profile today, and you will find something that would have seemed extraordinary a decade ago. Internships completed before the final year. Side projects with real traction. Volunteer work, creator pages, skill certifications, and, somewhere underneath, a human being who is still figuring out who they are.

The resume now starts in school. By the time a student reaches college, they have already been evaluated across dimensions that did not exist for the generation before them. For many students today, marks alone no longer feel sufficient. Now you need a passion project, which needs an audience. The pressure to do it all is real. But the more interesting story is what this generation is actually doing with it.

Building options

What surprises most people is how much clarity sits underneath all the activity. This is not a generation flailing around. Most young people today have a strong sense of who they want to become, and they treat the trying-out as a way to test and sharpen



Space to explore

Students are building impressive profiles earlier than before but are they losing sight of what actually matters?

that vision, not escape it. Research from Randstad India found that 43% of Gen Z want a full-time role paired with a side hustle. That is a generation deliberately building options for itself, on its own terms.

There is also a distinc-

tion between genuine interest and fear of falling behind. Both exist, and this generation is increasingly aware of the difference. When a young person finds something they love today, they go deeper than previous generations

could because they have the tools, the communities, and the confidence too.

The fear of falling behind is real too, and a social media feed full of everyone else's highlight reel makes it easy to feel like you are the only one not moving forward. But the encouraging shift is that young people are starting to name this pressure and push back.

Cost of visibility

What makes this pressure different is not just the volume of expectations but how visible it is. Today, young people are exposed to a constant stream of achievements, milestones, and success stories from people they may never even meet. The benchmark is no longer the people around them. It can feel like everyone.

The deeper cost is harder to measure. When every opportunity feels important and every achievement feels visible, it becomes harder to separate what you genuinely enjoy from what you feel expected to pursue. Young people can find themselves constantly optimising not because they lack direction but because there is always another skill to learn, another opportunity to

chase, or another benchmark to meet. Over time, it can become harder to distinguish genuine interest from external validation. They can end up with an impressive profile and very little sense of self. An impressive resume and an unclear identity are not a contradiction.

The response to the pressure is often adding more structure: more counselling, more workshops, more guided support. These matter. But the more important shift is subtler. The moment everything a student tries gets graded, ranked, or added to a profile, exploration stops being play. What young people actually need are spaces where they can try something, be average at it, and still feel it was worth their time. Where the attempt is celebrated and not just the outcome, so students stop fearing anything they might not win at.

The fix is not to lower ambition. It is to create environments where they can figure out what actually matters to them before performing a version of their life for everyone else's benefit. That is not a small ask. But it is the right one.

The writer is CEO, Under25.



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